

SBCL + Alive Extension Setup Guide

Get a full Common Lisp development environment running in VS Code — from installation to your first Hello World.

1 Install SBCL (Steel Bank Common Lisp)

DOWNLOAD

Get the Windows installer (.exe) from one of these sources:

Recommended — SBCL 2.6.4 (SourceForge):

sourceforge.net/projects/sbcl/files/sbcl/2.6.4/

All SBCL versions:

sourceforge.net/projects/sbcl/files/sbcl/

Alternative — Google Drive (Windows installers):

drive.google.com/drive/folders/1Sti8-kPzcj89uYL-ndYJgRGppJyYgMfg

INSTALL

Run the downloaded **.exe** installer and follow the setup wizard to completion.

VERIFY INSTALLATION

Confirm SBCL installed correctly using either of the two methods below:

Method A — Command Prompt (Open Windows CMD, not VS Code terminal)

Type `sbcl` to start the REPL

Type `(exit)` to quit

Type `where sbcl` to find the install path

Method B — Environment Variables

Open **System Properties** → **Advanced** →

Environment Variables and confirm **Steel Bank Common Lisp** appears in the PATH variable.

2 Install the Alive VS Code Extension

INSTALL THE EXTENSION

Install the **Alive** extension — the Lisp language server for VS Code.

marketplace.visualstudio.com – Alive Extension (rheller.alive)

Or search **Alive** in the VS Code Extensions panel (**Ctrl + Shift + X**).

CONFIGURE USER SETTINGS

Open the Command Palette with **Ctrl + Shift + P**, then search for and open **Preferences: Open User Settings (JSON)**. Add the following configuration block:

```
// settings.json
"alive.lsp.startCommand": [
  "sbcl",
  "--eval",
  "(require :asdf)",
  "--eval",
  "(asdf:load-system :alive-lsp)",
  "--eval",
  "(alive/server:start)"
]
```

i This tells VS Code to launch the Alive language server via SBCL automatically whenever you open a .lisp file.

3 Test Your Setup

CREATE A TEST FILE

Create a new file in VS Code named `test.lisp` and type the following:

```
(print "HELLO WORLD")
```

RUN IT

In the VS Code integrated terminal, run the script with SBCL:

```
sbcl --script test.lisp
```

✓ If you see "HELLO WORLD" printed in the terminal, your Common Lisp environment is fully set up and working correctly!

